MODULE 09 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Performance, motivation, coaching and emotional intelligence

What motivates people, how to handle underperformance, coaching and mentoring, emotional intelligence and psychological safety.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 09 of 49

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People do their best work when they feel **safe**, capable, and that the work matters.

Motivation theories you may meet

THEORY	CORE IDEA
Maslow's hierarchy	Basic needs first: security before belonging, belonging before esteem and growth
Herzberg's two factors	Hygiene factors prevent dissatisfaction; motivators create satisfaction
McGregor's X and Y	Assumptions about people shape how they are managed
McClelland's needs	People are driven by achievement, affiliation or power, in different mixes
Vroom's expectancy	Effort depends on believing it leads to results, and that the results are valued
Pink's drive	Autonomy, mastery and purpose drive knowledge work

ON THE EXAM

The exam rarely names a theory. It describes a situation that one of these explains.

Herzberg: hygiene factors or motivators?

HYGIENE FACTORS

Prevent dissatisfaction

- Pay and working conditions
- Equipment and tools
- Policies and job security
- Relationships with supervisors

MOTIVATORS

Create satisfaction

- Achievement
- Recognition
- Interesting work
- Responsibility and growth

THE TIEBREAKER

Motivators cannot fix a hygiene problem. Pizza and awards do not compensate for broken laptops.

Theory X or Theory Y?

THEORY X ASSUMES

People avoid work

- Need close supervision
- Motivated by pay and fear
- Avoid responsibility
- Leads to micromanagement

THEORY Y ASSUMES

People want to contribute

- Self-directed if committed
- Motivated by meaning and growth
- Seek responsibility
- Leads to empowerment

THE TIEBREAKER

Agile and servant leadership assume Theory Y. Answers built on Theory X usually lose.

Autonomy, mastery and purpose

- **Autonomy**: control over how the work is done. Agile teams self-organise.
- **Mastery**: getting better at something that matters. Learning, pairing, feedback.
- **Purpose**: knowing why the work matters. A clear vision, and seeing the users benefit.
- For knowledge work, bigger bonuses tied to targets can reduce creativity rather than increase it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A demotivated knowledge worker usually lacks autonomy, growth or purpose. Money is rarely the fix.

Recognition and rewards

- **Timely and specific**: soon after the contribution, naming what was valuable.
- **Fit the person**: some value public praise, some private thanks, some development.
- **Team-based** for team results, especially in agile work.
- Win-lose individual competitions damage collaboration inside a team.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Reward the behaviour you want more of. For collaborative work, that means rewarding the team.

Emotional intelligence: four areas

AREA	ABOUT	LOOKS LIKE
Self-awareness	Knowing your own emotions	Noticing you are frustrated before you reply
Self-management	Controlling your reactions	Pausing, staying calm under pressure
Social awareness	Reading others' emotions	Empathy; noticing someone has gone quiet
Relationship management	Handling relationships well	Influence, conflict handling, coaching

ON THE EXAM

Self first, then others. You cannot manage a tense meeting until you have managed yourself.

Emotional intelligence under pressure

- When someone is angry, **stay calm, listen, and acknowledge** their concern first.
- Move heated discussions somewhere **private**, and come back with facts.
- Notice changes in behaviour, such as withdrawal or irritability, and **check in privately**.
- Defending yourself, blaming others, or matching the other person's tone all escalate the situation.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Acknowledge the emotion before addressing the facts. It is what lets the facts be heard.

A team is safe when people can speak up, admit mistakes and disagree **without fear**.

How leaders build psychological safety

- **Admit your own mistakes** and uncertainty first. It gives others permission.
- **Invite dissent** explicitly: 'What might we be missing?'
- **Thank people for bad news**. How you react the first time decides whether there is a second time.
- Run **blameless** reviews: look at the system, not the culprit.
- One public put-down can undo months of effort.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Safety is built by the leader's reactions, not by announcements. Model it, and protect it.

Coaching or mentoring?

COACHING

Improve a specific performance

- Focused on a skill or goal
- Mostly asks questions
- Shorter term
- Coach need not be an expert in the role

MENTORING

Grow over the long term

- Focused on career and development
- Shares experience and advice
- Longer term relationship
- Mentor is experienced in the field

THE TIEBREAKER

A specific skill gap: coaching or training. Long-term growth and career: mentoring.

Acting on mentoring opportunities

- The outline asks you to **organise and act on mentoring opportunities**, as part of aligning stakeholders.
- Pair less experienced team members with experienced ones, inside the project.
- Offer to mentor people who want to grow, including future project leaders.
- Mentoring can run both ways: a new stakeholder can be mentored on how the project works.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Mentoring is part of the job, not a favour. Look for the opportunity in the scenario.

Handling underperformance

01

Private conversation

Describe what you observed, and listen.

02

Find the cause

Skill, clarity, motivation, workload or personal?

03

Agree a plan

Expectations, plus support: training, coaching, rebalancing.

04

Follow up

Check progress and recognise improvement.

05

Escalate

To the functional manager, only if it persists.

ON THE EXAM

Understand before you act. Formal warnings and replacements come last, not first.

Match the response to the cause

THE CAUSE	THE RESPONSE
Missing skill	Training, coaching or pairing
Unclear expectations	Clarify the goal, the standard and the role
Low motivation	Understand why; reconnect with purpose, growth or recognition
Too much work	Rebalance, reprioritise, protect a sustainable pace
Personal difficulty	Support, flexibility, and signposting to help

ON THE EXAM

The same symptom, late or poor work, has five different causes. The fix depends on which one.

Giving feedback that helps

- **Situation, behaviour, impact**: when it happened, what exactly was done, and what effect it had.
- **Timely**, while the event is fresh. Not saved up for an appraisal.
- Praise in public if the person welcomes it. **Correct in private**, always.
- Vague feedback, such as 'be more proactive', gives the person nothing to change.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Specific and timely beats general and delayed. Corrective feedback is always private.

Sustainable pace and burnout

- Warning signs: long hours becoming normal, rising errors, irritability, withdrawal, sick days.
- Respond by **rebalancing work** and **adjusting scope or dates**, with stakeholders.
- Sustainable pace is an agile principle, and people's wellbeing is part of accountable leadership.
- More overtime to recover a late project is a short-term loan at a very high rate.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> An exhausted team is a risk to the project. Treat it as one.

Project Lantern: keeping people at their best

- The clinic coordinators are **paired with a go-live veteran** from the first clinic.
- The app team's retrospectives are **blameless**; the project manager shares their own misjudgements first.
- Patient panel feedback is shown to the developers every sprint, so they **see the purpose**.
- When the data migration team hit weeks of late nights, scope was re-sequenced with the sponsor.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Mentoring, safety, purpose and pace: four levers, used on one project.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
A good performer's work suddenly slips	Private conversation; find the cause
Team unhappy about equipment or conditions	Fix the hygiene factor, not more rewards
Nobody raises problems; mistakes are hidden	Build psychological safety; blameless reviews
Someone wants to grow into a new role	Mentoring and stretch opportunities
A stakeholder is angry in a meeting	Stay calm, acknowledge, follow up privately with facts
A team result, an individual prize	Recognise the team

ON THE EXAM

Safe, capable, purposeful: find which of the three is missing, and restore it.

> A developer who has always met commitments has missed three in a row since the team adopted a new cloud platform.
>
> He has not raised any problems, and his colleagues seem comfortable with the platform.

What should the project manager do?

A Issue a formal warning about the missed commitments.

B Meet him privately to understand the cause, and arrange training or pairing if it is a skills gap.

C Reassign his platform work to colleagues who are comfortable with it.

D Report the missed commitments to his functional manager.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Formal warning.

Punishes before understanding. The timing points to a skills gap, not attitude.

B Private conversation, then training or pairing.

Finds the cause privately and matches the response to it.

C Reassign his work.

Avoids the gap instead of closing it, and sidelines him on the new platform.

D Report to his manager.

Escalates before a single conversation has happened.

THE SIGNAL

A reliable person slips right after a change: suspect a skills gap, and ask privately.

> A team complains repeatedly about slow, outdated laptops that crash during builds. Morale is falling.
>
> The project manager has arranged team lunches and a monthly recognition award, but the complaints continue.

What should the project manager do next?

A Increase the value of the monthly recognition award.

B Organise a team-building day to lift morale.

C Work with management to get the laptops upgraded or replaced.

D Ask the team to focus on delivery and avoid complaining.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do next?

A Bigger award.

A motivator cannot fix a hygiene factor. It has already failed once.

B Team-building day.

Nice, and irrelevant to crashing laptops.

C Get the laptops fixed.

Removes the source of dissatisfaction. Also a real productivity impediment.

D Stop complaining.

Dismisses a legitimate problem and damages trust.

THE SIGNAL

Dissatisfaction from conditions: fix the hygiene factor. Motivators will not compensate.

> At a recent sprint review, a senior manager sharply criticised a developer who reported a defect she had found in her own code.
>
> Since then, nobody has raised problems in retrospectives, and two defects were found only by customers.

What should the project leader do?

A. Ask each team member directly, in the next retrospective, to name one problem.

B. Cancel retrospectives until the team is ready to contribute.

C. Rebuild safety: blameless retrospectives, anonymous input, and a private word with the senior manager.

D. File a formal complaint about the senior manager with human resources.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Put each person on the spot.
Pressure without safety. People will name trivial problems, or none.

B Cancel retrospectives.
Removes the forum just when it is needed most.

C Blameless, anonymous input, private word with the manager.
Rebuilds safety in the team and addresses its cause.

D Formal HR complaint.
Premature. A private conversation has not been tried.

THE SIGNAL

Problems stopped surfacing after someone was punished for raising one: rebuild psychological safety.

> A capable business analyst on the project tells the project manager she would like to become a project manager within two years.
>
> She asks for advice on how to get there.

What should the project manager do?

A Recommend a certification course and leave her to arrange it.

B Offer to mentor her, and give her a small workstream to lead on the project.

C Arrange a coach to improve her analysis skills.

D Suggest she speaks to her functional manager about career plans.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Recommend a course only.

Useful, but hands off. It misses the chance to mentor.

B Mentor her; give her a workstream.

Acts on a mentoring opportunity, with real experience attached.

C A coach for analysis skills.

Coaching targets a current skill. Her goal is long-term growth into a new role.

D Send her to her manager.

Deflects a request the PM is well placed to help with.

THE SIGNAL

Long-term growth into a new role: mentoring, plus a real opportunity to practise.

> In a steering meeting, a regional director raises his voice at the project manager about a two-week delay to his region's go-live.
>
> Part of the delay was caused by his own team's late approval of the site plans.

How should the project manager respond?

A. Stay calm, acknowledge his concern, and arrange a private follow-up with the facts and a recovery plan.

B. Point out that his own team's late approvals caused much of the delay.

C. End the meeting until he is ready to discuss the issue calmly.

D. Report his behaviour to the sponsor after the meeting.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the project manager respond?

A Calm, acknowledge, private follow-up with facts.

Self-management first, then empathy; the facts come later, privately.

B Blame his team.

True, but said in public and in anger it escalates and humiliates.

C End the meeting.

Disrupts every other attendee and leaves the concern hanging.

D Report him to the sponsor.

Escalates a relationship the PM has not tried to repair.

THE SIGNAL

An angry stakeholder in public: manage yourself, acknowledge them, and bring the facts privately.

> An agile team delivered a major release early through a collective effort. Several members covered for each other and paired on the hardest problems.
>
> Senior management wants to name one developer 'employee of the quarter' for the release.

What should the project manager recommend?

A Support the award, since recognition motivates people.

B Ask the team to vote for the one person who should receive it.

C Decline any recognition, to avoid favouritism.

D Recommend recognising the whole team for the release.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager recommend?

A Support the individual award.

Singles out one person for a collective result, and undermines collaboration.

B Team votes for one person.

Turns colleagues into competitors for recognition they earned together.

C No recognition.

Wastes a real motivator. The team did something worth recognising.

D Recognise the whole team.

Rewards the collaborative behaviour that produced the result.

THE SIGNAL

A team result earns team recognition. Reward the behaviour you want repeated.

Safe, capable, purposeful. Find what is missing before you act.

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